

Smart Siri

Siri in iOS 7 will ask users to teach her to pronounce a difficult name. We can't wait to throw some Indian names at her



Outlook Web Apps

OWA launched in two new versions for iPhone and iPad users, utilising Office 365 subscription and native integration

ASUS ROG OC PANEL

The OC Panel is an accessory that is bundled with the ASUS Maximus VI Extreme board. It has a lovely black/gray coloured body, a 2.6-inch screen, a stand (if it is used externally) as well as a 5.25-inch bay bracket if you plan to house the panel within your cabinet. The screen can rotate by 90 degrees which allows it to be easily mounted in the 5.25-inch bracket. On the left hand edge it has a Sub-zero sense temperature monitoring tool meant for the LN2 crowd. OC Panel offers real-time monitoring of various parameters such as CPU clock speeds, voltages, fan speeds and so on. There are four buttons: Normal/Extreme mode switch; One-click CPU level up; Power button and FanSpeed controller. Apart from this there is the directional pad on the front face of the OC Panel.

Opening up the OC Panel reveals a circuitry which has four fan connectors, extra resistors and capacitors for VGA mods. The Panel is powered either by an OC panel connector (if used as an external monitor) or by SATA power connector.

Monitoring statuses was a breeze and in the extreme mode we were able to adjust BCLK and CPU ratio on the fly. The display is quite sharp, but we found the limited space allotted to debug code and scrolling notifications a bit annoying. On the whole, it is quite an innovative accessory.



and the DirectKey allows you to go to BIOS on rebooting without any need to press Del key repeatedly.

Finally we have the Gigabyte Z87X-UD3H which has an understated but lovely matte-black colour. It is well laid out and has dedicated power/reset and clear CMOS buttons, sturdy looking heatsinks, eight SATA ports and two USB 3.0 internal connectors. Beside the SATA ports you will notice a SATA power connector for providing additional power to the PCIe slots when you are using a three-way GPU setup.

All boards in this category successfully overclocked the processor to 4.6GHz and gave

around 20 per cent boost in readings. When it came to bundled utilities, we felt that the ones from Gigabyte and ASUS were much superior. ASUS's AI Suite III offers lots of options to monitor and tweak settings. Gigabyte have revamped their tuning utility as well, which has a more Windows 8-tile like look and feel. It provides the option to update BIOS, control fan speeds, overclock and so on from the same parent utility. Even Intel's Extreme Tuning Utility was a great application for overclocking.

15k to 20k

This segment had two boards each from ASUS and MSI and

one board from ECS. In terms of performance there isn't much of a difference from other segments, but with these boards you get additional features such as extra SATA ports, USB 3.0 ports, extra PCIe 3.0 slots and so on which enable you to build a high-end rig.

Let us start off with the ECS Z87XH3-A2X Extreme which is also called the Gank Machine. It has a very interesting passive cooler which also has a small fan on one side. This Qooltech V heatsink is connected to the south-bridge heatsink via a heatpipe. The chipset heatsink is intricately designed for faster heat dissipation and has a temperature sensitive sticker. It has a plethora of buttons on the lower corner for power/reset, ROM backup, overclocking and so on. It also packs in an mSATA port in the space between the heatsink and the buttons.

MSI had two very different boards – MSI Z87 MPower targetted at overclockers and MSI Z87-GD65 for gamers. The Z87-GD65 Gaming board looks quite attractive with its black/maroon colour tones (with the maroon accents seen only on the heatsinks) and the impressive sculpted dragon on the south-bridge heatsink. The heatsinks are elaborately designed to dissipate heat faster. The MSI Z87 MPower on the other hand has a black/yellow colour tone with yellow seen on the heatsinks which have a comparatively simpler design as compared to the gaming board. In terms of the layout, both the boards have identical number of PCIe slots but on the MPower board, the mSATA slot is present between



MSI Z87 MPower

the first two PCIe x16 slots whereas on the gaming board, the mSATA connector is present before the first PCIe x16 slot. The number of physical buttons on the MPower boards exceeds those on the GD65, but both come with the OC Genie button for overclocking to preset values. The audio section on the MPower board is isolated whereas it isn't on the GD65 which we found a bit strange. We liked the fact that the USB 3.0 connector on both the boards is placed at 90 degrees to the board.

ASUS had two boards – the Z87 Pro and Maximus VI Hero. The Z87 Pro comes with the black/yellow colouring seen on the Z87-A board but the heatsinks on Z87 Pro are more elaborate. The board appears quite dense and the layout is good with enough clearance for the CPU cooler and enough spacing between PCIe x16 slots. The Maximus VI Hero is a notch below the Maximus VI Extreme in the Republic of Gamers (ROG) hierarchy. The Hero has the typical red/black theme, sturdy heatsinks, eight SATA ports, dedicated power reset buttons among other things.

In terms of overclocking the ASUS boards were quite impressive with the Hero taking the Intel Core i7-4770K to 4.72GHz. With the ECS